Term Guide

For the less technical folks in our community

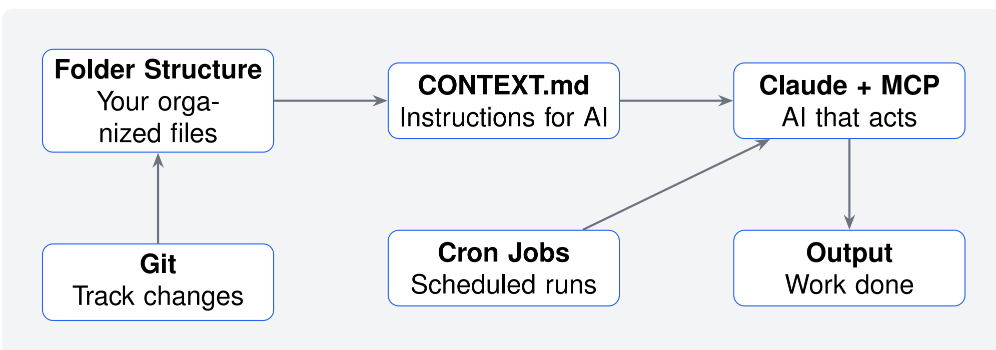
Clief Notes Community | March 12, 2026

How to use this guide

This document explains the technical terms you will encounter in our community posts, videos, and discussions. Each term includes a plain-English definition, a visual analogy to help it stick, and links to learn more if you want to go deeper.

The Big Picture

Before diving into individual terms, here is how everything connects:



The folder structure is the API. Everything else plugs into it.

Foundational Concepts

These are the building blocks. Understand these first.

Folder Structure / File Architecture

Exactly what it sounds like: folders on your computer, organized in a specific way. The magic is not in the folders themselves but in *how* you organize them and *what instructions* you put inside.

> *Think of it like a filing cabinet. The cabinet itself is simple. The power comes from having a system: invoices in one drawer, contracts in another, each labeled clearly. Anyone who understands your system can find what they need.*

In our system, each folder represents one *stage* of a workflow. The folder contains instructions (CONTEXT.md) that tell the AI what to do at that stage.

API (Application Programming Interface)

A way for two systems to talk to each other using agreed-upon rules.[a]

> *A waiter in a restaurant. You (the customer) do not walk into the kitchen. Instead, you tell the waiter what you want. The waiter takes your request to the kitchen, the kitchen prepares it, and the waiter brings it back. The waiter is the API.*

When I say "the folder structure is the API," I mean the folders become the communication layer. Change a text file, change the behavior. No code required.

What is an API? (freeCodeCamp)

[a] The term "interface" is key here. Just like a light switch is an interface between you and the electrical system, an API is an interface between software systems.

CONTEXT.md

A plain text file (in Markdown format) that tells the AI what a specific stage of your workflow is supposed to do. It is the instruction manual for that folder.[a]

> *A recipe card. It tells the cook (the AI) what ingredients to expect, what steps to follow, and what the finished dish should look like. Change the recipe, change the output.*

This is where non-technical users gain control. You do not need to write code. You edit a text file. The AI reads it and follows the instructions.

Getting Started with Markdown

[a] Markdown is a simple way to format text using symbols like # for headings and * for bullet points. You are probably already familiar with it from apps like Notion or Slack.

Version Control (Tracking Changes)

These terms relate to how you save, share, and collaborate on files without losing work.

Git

A system that tracks every change made to your files over time. It lets multiple people work on the same project without overwriting each other, and keeps a complete history of every edit.[a]

Google Docs version history, but for your entire project. You can see who changed what, when they changed it, and roll back to any previous version if something breaks.

What is Git? (Official Docs)

[a] Git was created by Linus Torvalds in 2005, the same person who created Linux. It is now the industry standard for version control.

Repo (Repository)

A project folder managed by Git. Contains your files plus the complete history of every change made to them.

A project binder with a built-in time machine. The binder holds your current work. The time machine lets you see (and restore) any previous version.

Commit

A saved snapshot in Git. When you "commit," you are saving the current state of your files with a note describing what changed.

> *Taking a photo of your desk before rearranging it. If the new arrangement does not work, you can look at the photo and put everything back.*

Good commit messages are like journal entries: "Added error handling to stage 3" tells your future self (or teammates) exactly what happened.

Fork

Making your own copy of someone else's repository. You can modify your copy freely without affecting the original.

> *Photocopying a recipe from a cookbook. You can write all over your copy, make substitutions, cross things out. The original cookbook stays untouched on the shelf.*

Upstream

The original source you forked from. If I maintain the main repo and you fork it, my version is "upstream" from yours.

> *The source of a river. Water flows downstream. Updates flow from upstream (the original) to downstream (your fork). You can "pull" updates from upstream to keep your copy current.*

GitHub Actions

Automated tasks that run when something happens in your repository. Push new code? GitHub can automatically test it, deploy it, or trigger other workflows.[a]

> *A diligent assistant who watches your inbox. "When a new document arrives, scan it for errors, file it in the right folder, and notify the team." You set the rules once. The assistant follows them forever.*

Understanding GitHub Actions

[a]GitHub is the most popular platform for hosting Git repositories. GitHub Actions is their built-in automation system.

Automation (Making Things Run Themselves)

These terms relate to scheduling and running tasks automatically.

Cron Job

A scheduled task that runs automatically at times you set. Available on Mac, Linux, and (with some setup) Windows.[a]

> *An alarm clock for your computer. "Every Monday at 9am, run this script." You set it once. It runs forever (or until you tell it to stop).*

Common patterns: daily backups, hourly data syncs, weekly reports. Pair a cron job with your folder architecture and the system runs itself.

Crontab Guru (interactive scheduler)

[a]The name "cron" comes from the Greek word "chronos" meaning time. Cron has been part of Unix systems since 1975.

MCP (Model Context Protocol)

A standard way to connect Claude to external tools and data sources. Developed by Anthropic.[a]

> 💡 *Giving Claude hands. Without MCP, Claude can only talk. With MCP, Claude can open files, check calendars, send emails, query databases, and take real actions in the world.*

🔌 This is what turns a chatbot into an automation engine. Your CONTEXT.md files tell Claude what to do. MCP gives Claude the ability to actually do it.

Model Context Protocol (Official Site)

[a]Anthropic is the company that builds Claude. MCP was released in late 2024 as an open protocol.

The Layer System (MWP Architecture)

These terms are specific to the folder-based architecture I teach.

L3 / L4 (Layer 3, Layer 4)

Part of the MWP (Model Workspace Protocol) system.[a]
L3 is reference material: templates, examples, rules. This is the “factory.”
L4 is where actual work happens: drafts, outputs, deliverables. This is the “product.”

> 💡 *L3 is the assembly line and the blueprints. L4 is the cars rolling off that line. You (the builder) control the factory. Your clients work with the product.*

This separation is what makes the system safe to hand off. Clients can configure what the factory produces. They cannot break the factory itself.

[a]The full layer stack is: L0 (identity), L1 (routing), L2 (stage contract), L3 (reference/factory), L4 (working artifacts/product). Most users interact with L3 and L4.

Alternative Tools (For Context)

You will hear these mentioned in our community. They solve similar problems in different ways.

n8n

A visual automation tool where you connect "nodes" (blocks) together to build workflows. Open source and self-hostable.[a]

Building with LEGO. Each block does one thing. You snap them together in a chain. Data flows from block to block until you reach the end.

Popular and powerful, but complexity grows fast. The folder-based approach we teach avoids the visual spaghetti by making each stage a self-contained folder with plain-text instructions.

n8n Official Site

[a]Pronounced "n-eight-n" or sometimes "nodemation." Similar tools include Zapier (cloud-based, paid) and Make (formerly Integromat).

LangGraph

A Python framework for building AI agent workflows. Part of the LangChain ecosystem.[a]

Writing a script for a play where the actors (AI agents) can improvise based on audience reactions. More flexible than simple automation, but requires programming knowledge.

LangGraph Documentation

[a]LangChain is one of the most popular frameworks for building LLM applications. LangGraph extends it to handle multi-step, stateful agent workflows.

Nodes

In visual tools like n8n, nodes are the individual blocks you wire together. Each node does one thing: send an email, call an API, transform data, make a decision.

Stations on an assembly line. Part arrives at station 1, gets processed, moves to station 2, and so on. Each station has one job.

> In our folder-based system, each folder is like a node, but you define its behavior with a text file instead of clicking through a visual interface.

Quick Reference

Term	One-Line Definition
Folder Structure	Organized folders that control AI behavior
API	How two systems talk to each other
CONTEXT.md	Plain-text instructions for the AI
Git	Tracks every change to your files
Repo	A project folder managed by Git
Commit	A saved snapshot with a description
Fork	Your personal copy of someone else's repo
Upstream	The original source you forked from
GitHub Actions	Automated tasks triggered by repo events
Cron Job	Scheduled task that runs automatically
MCP	Gives Claude the ability to take actions
L3 (Factory)	Reference material and templates you control
L4 (Product)	Working artifacts your clients interact with
n8n	Visual automation tool using connected blocks
LangGraph	Python framework for AI agent workflows
Nodes	Individual blocks in a visual workflow tool

Questions? Drop them in the community. We read everything.

skool.com/quantum-quill-lyceum-1116